

A FAD DIET FOR YOUR WALLET

Super popular budget guru Dave Ramsey tries to get his followers to save toward a \$1,000 emergency fund that is not to be touched unless it's for a dire situation like a collapsed roof or an appendectomy. This is different from a "Mistakes" fund for cleaning up messes you've made for yourself, which many experts advocate for *on top of* a savings account, an emergency fund, and a retirement account. But the two are in the same family. Writer Paulette Perhach calls on women specifically to have an "F-Off Fund" for getting out of abusive relationships or leaving jobs where they're being harassed, let's say. These different savings funds are made from budgeting HARD.

Ramsey *really* believes in budgeting, which puts him at odds with another famous finance guru, Suze Orman. She believes budgeting is a fad diet that people don't ever stick to, and when they lose it, they binge hard. Orman, however, did recommend on Oprah's website in 2016 that when it comes to a budget, you should set aside \$50 a month from your income for "treats." Everything else should go to "necessities."

Orman has fans, but Ramsey has DEVOTEES. There are endless Dave Ramsey followers on YouTube, where I spend a lot of my time. A trip down the Ramsey YouTube hole led me to a fascinating channel, "Life with Sarah." Sarah, a young woman based in Texas, said she learned to sacrifice big-time from Ramsey. She cut her cable, for example, and uses her videos to chronicle her strict budgeting in her life with her husband. Sarah's enthusiasm is infectious, and she's clearly very savvy, so I don't know how to feel about the extreme sparse lifestyle she preaches in Ramsey's name.

To be completely honest, hearing people talk about intense budgeting makes me nervous from a political standpoint. I think it's the idea that the proles are supposed to fix their problems with self-deprivation, giving up getting haircuts